No subject island in Chinese, yet discourse factors still matter

Among constraints on long-distance dependencies(Ross 1967), the subject island was argued (e.g., Chomsky 1973; Huang 1982) to prohibit extraction from subjects. Recent experimental work challenges this view. Abeillé et al. (2020) and Winckel et al. (2025) found a subject penalty in wh-questions and it-clefts in English and French, but not in relative clauses with pied piping, and the same holds for Italian (Sprouse et al 2016). They propose a Focus Background Conflict (FBC) constraint, so that a filler should not be more focussed than the gap. Since subjects typically convey backgrounded information, extraction conflicts with focalizing wh-questions and clefts, but not with non-focalizing relative clauses. Testing this account across languages is thus crucial. Mandarin Chinese is different since it allows null arguments, favors wh-in-situ questions, and has head-final relative clauses. Using the same negation test as Winckel et al (2025), Mao (2025) found no difference in backgroundness between Chinese subjects and objects, so that FBC predicts no subject penalty for Chinese, unlike in English or French. According to Huang et al. (2009), extraction from objects is generally degraded in Chinese, while extraction from subjects is acceptable, thus an object penalty. They propose a Generalized Control Rule, which requires a null pronoun to be coindexed with the nearest c-commanding antecedent, hence a subject advantage. Hsu (2009) argues that the acceptability of extraction from subjects and objects depends on whether a contrast is accessible in the speaker's mental representation, given Krifka's (2007) definition of focus as involving a set of alternatives. Under this account, focus extraction is predicted to be more acceptable than its non-focus counterpart.

We conducted 4 acceptability judgment experiments on Chinese: E1 wh-fronting (subject vs. object; control vs. bare-extract vs. focus-extract), E2 wh-fronting with resumptive pronouns (subject vs. object; control vs. bare-extract vs. focus-extract), E3 wh-in-situ (subject vs. object; control vs. wh-in-situ vs. focused wh-in-situ), E4 relative clauses (subject vs. object, control vs. RC vs. RC with resumptive pronouns). With Bayesian analyses, in E1 and E2, we found an object penalty (E1: $\beta = -0.513$, 95% CI: [-1,03, -0.0128], $p(\beta < 0) = 0.978$; E2: $\beta = -0.125$, 95% CI: [-0.684, -0.0180], $p(\beta < 0) = 0.969$), and this penalty was reduced when a focus marker marked the fronted element (E1: $\beta = -0.327$, 95% CI: [-0.842,0.174], $p(\beta < 0) = 0.903$; E2: $\beta = -0.125$, 95% CI: [-0.454, 0.204], $p(\beta < 0) = 0.773$). This is consistent with both Huang's Generalized Control Rule and Hsu (2009)'s discourse-based account. In E3 we found no extraction penalty, consistent with non-movement accounts of wh-in-situ (bare wh-in-situ: $\beta = 0.120$, 95% CI: [-0.398, 0.634], $p(\beta < 0) = 0.682$; focused wh-in-situ: $\beta = -0.0637$, 95% CI: [-0.555, 0.423], $p(\beta < 0) = 0.607$), challenging the covert movement analysis. Chinese RCs with and without resumptive pronouns patterned alike without any extraction penalties ($\beta = 0.0921$, 95% CI: [−0.248, 0.431], $p(\beta > 0) = 0.71$; $\beta = 0.0878$, 95% CI: [−0.214, 0.390], $p(\beta > 0) = 0.719$), suggesting no gap (or null pronoun) for Chinese relative clauses. In conclusion, we found no evidence for a subject island in Chinese, but discourse factors still play a role in the object penalty for wh-fronting. The results also suggest base-generation for Chinese wh-questions (wh-fronting and wh-in-situ) and RCs.

Selected references: Abeillé et al (2020) Extraction from subjects: Differences in acceptability depend on the discourse function of the construction. *Cognition*; Hsu (2009) Possessor Extraction in Mandarin Chinese; Huang (1982). Logical relations in Chinese and the theory of grammar; Huang (2009) The syntax of Chinese; Mao (2005) Meaning-based Approaches to Locality Constraints: Extraction from English and Chinese Adjuncts and Subjects.

E1 Wh-fronting : Subject: (Shi) Na-ge daxue paiming, _kekaoxing kunrao jiaoshi xihui?
(FM) which-CL university ranking, _credibility distress teacher union?
Object: (Shi) Na-ge daxue paiming, jiaoshi xiehui zhiyi _ kekuoxing?
(FM) which-CL university ranking, teacher union question _ credibility?

E3 Wh-in-situ Subject: (Zhiyou) nage daxue paiming de kexindu kunrao jiaoshi xiehui?
(FM) which university ranking DE credibility trouble teacher union
Object: Jiaoshi xiehui zhiyi (de zhiyou) nage daxue paiming de kexindu?
teacher union question (FM) which university ranking DE credibility
E4: RCs Subject: Zhongwa Ribao gongbu-le yi-fen (qi) kekaoxing kunrao-le jiaoshi xiehui de daxue paiming.
Sino-foreign daily publish-LE one-CL (RP) reliability distress-LE teacher union DE university ranking
Object: Zhongwai Ribao gongbu-le yi-fen jiaoshi xiehui feichang zhiyi (qi) kekaoxing de daxue paiming.
Sino-foreign daily publish-LE one-CL teacher.union strongly question (RP) reliability DE university ranking

E1: wh-fronting without resumptive pronouns

E2:wh-fronting with resumptive pronouns

E3: wh-in-situ

E4:relative clauses (with and without RP)